Preposition Placement in Learner English

Acceptability Depends on Input Frequency and Cross-Linguistic Similarity

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– hello everyone, thank you for coming
– I am ... from ... in ...
– I would like to talk to you about Preposition Placement in Learner English, more precisely, Preposition Placement in RCs in Second Language Learner English
– I propose that the acceptability of the constructions in question depends on input frequency and cross-linguistic similarity

On preposition placement in English

(1) a. **To whom** should I complain? (BNC)

b. **Who** should I complain **to**?

(2) a. Inevitably, however, they took over many factual and theoretical shortcomings from the anthropologists **on whom** they relied and [...]. (BNC)

b. [...] the anthropologists **who** they relied **on** and [...].

(Pullum & Huddleston, 2002; Hamilton, 1994)

– as is well-known and as their name suggests, prepositions normally precede their complement in English but, in some English constructions, the situation is strangely different
– for example, in interrogative clauses (1), the preposition *to* may be placed either at the beginning of the clause preceding the complement *wh* pronoun (1a); ... ; or the preposition may be left 'bald' at the end of the clause (1b)
– to the former (1a), I refer as 'preposition fronting', to the latter (1b) as 'preposition stranding'
– preposition stranding is not unique to English but typologically rare; preposition fronting is typologically more common than stranding (Hamilton, 1994)
– for another example from English, oblique *wh* RCs like (2); again, the *wh* pronoun is the object of a preposition; this preposition may either be fronted to clause-initial position and immediately precede the *wh* pronoun (2a); ... ; or the preposition may be left stranded at a position following the verb *relied* (2b)
– **in the following, I will only be concerned with preposition placement in oblique *wh* RCs**

Earlier research

Table: Overview of factors influencing preposition placement in language use

clause type
RC:relativizer
RC:finiteness
RC:restrictiveness
RC:antecedent_type
RC:type_of_PP
RC:specific_items
RC:modality
RC:extraction_site
RC:formality
...

Table: Overview of earlier literature

language use, corpus-based
Hoffmann (2011)
Gries (2002)
Trotta (2000)
Bergh and Seppänen (2000)
Johansson and Geisler (1998)
and others
acquisition, experimental
Bardovi-Harlig (1987)
Mazurkewich (1985)
Kao (2001)
McDaniel et al. (1998)
and others

– the distribution of preposition fronting and stranding in language use depends on various factors and factor associations, some of which I listed in the table on the left
– on the right, you see a selection of relevant earlier literature
– recently, Thomas Hoffmann has described, compared, and explained preposition placement in the British and Kenyan parts of the International Corpus of English; there is a similar multifactorial analysis by Gries (2002) and a study by Trotta (2000) based on the Brown corpus, to name but a few
– comparatively little work has been done on preposition placement in learner language, except of some early experimental studies in generative linguistics (for example, Bardovi-Harlig, 1987; Mazurkewich, 1985; McDaniel, McKee, & Bernstein, 1998)
– **notably, to my knowledge, all earlier SLA studies left the learners' first language out of consideration**

My study

focus

- preposition placement in RCs (fronting/stranding)
- English as a second language
- role of the first language (German/Chinese)

data

- acceptability ratings

assumptions

- usage-based approach to language learning (e.g., Tomasello, 2003; Ellis & Collins, 2009; Ellis & Sagarra, 2011)

hypotheses

1. acceptability is contingent on frequency in English input

– therefore, I focused on preposition placement in RCs in English as a second language; in particular, I focused on the role of the first language: I compared German to Chinese learners of English, for reasons I will address in a moment
– for my empirical investigation, I elicited acceptability judgements from the respective learner populations and native language users
– I adopted the usage-based approach to language learning according to which learners acquire languages based on their experiences of language use: in other words, usage-based reseachers assume that learners gradually become attuned to the distributional patterns of forms and meanings in their linguistic input
– thus, I hypothesized, first, that the acceptability of fronting and stranding would be contingent on the distribution of the constructions in language use
– importantly, SL learners have already become attuned to the linguistic cues, probabilities, and contingencies in their first-language input and, therefore, second-language input passes through a first-language-specific attentional grid (e.g., Ellis & Sagarra, 2011)
– in contrast to earlier research in generative linguistics, I therefore expected usage-based cross-linguistic influence
– so, we need to have a look at preposition placement in German and Chinese RCs

On preposition placement in German and Chinese

(3) a. *Ich habe keinen bestimmten Typ,* ***auf den*** *ich stehe.*
I have no particular type on whom I stand

'There is no particular type (of man or woman) who I like.' (LCC)

b. * Ich habe keinen bestimmten Typ, **den** ich stehe **auf**.

(4) *wǒ xiūlǐ shuǐ guǎnzi de jùzi* (Li & Thompson, 1981, p. 581)
I repair water pipe NOM saw

'the saw with which I repair the water pipe'

(Li & Thompson, 1981; Fabricius-Hansen, Gallmann, & Eisenberg, 2005)

– in German RCs, only fronting is acceptable but not stranding
– for example, in (3); ... ; the RC *auf den ich stehe* ('who I like or for whom I fall') modifies the nominal *Typ* ('type (of man or woman)'); the relative pronoun *den* refers to *Typ*, agrees with the modified nominal in gender and number and is marked for accusative case, assigned by the preposition *auf*
– moreover and importantly, note that German and English fronting RCs have in common the position of the fronted preposition preceding the *wh* word and, moreover, they share word order to a considerable extent: in both English and German, the RC follows the modified nominal and, prototypically, has the word order OBJECT/ADJUNCT – SUBJECT – VERB
– compare all this to Chinese
– in contrast to English and German, in Chinese, a preposition is neither needed nor acceptable, the RC precedes the noun and has the word order SUBJECT – VERB – OBJECT
– for example, in a Chinese RC like (4); ... ; the RC *wǒ xiūlǐ shuǐ guǎnzi de* ('I repair water pipe') modifies the nominal *jùzi* ('saw'); the particle *de* indicates that the clause *wǒ xiūlǐ shuǐ guǎnzi* is nominalized; the relativized element is normally not overtly represented in the RC but gapped
– again, in Chinese, a preposition is neither needed nor acceptable in this construction, hence, the question of where to place a preposition, fronted or stranded, does not arise

My study

focus

- preposition placement in RCs
- English as a second language
- role of the first languages German and Chinese

data

- acceptability ratings

assumptions

- usage-based approach to language learning (e.g., Tomasello, 2003; Ellis & Collins, 2009)

hypotheses

1. acceptability is contingent on frequency in English input
2. fronting is more acceptable to German than Chinese learners
3. effect predicted in 2 increases with translational equivalence

– therefore, I hypothesized, second, that fronting would be more acceptable to German than Chinese learners due to the observed cross-linguistic similarity
– and third, I hypothesized that the effect predicted in 2 would increase with translational equivalence highlighting the cross-linguistic similarity

Subjects

Table: Part of a detailed questionnaire about participants biography and learner history; sample mean where applicable

L1	German	Chinese	English
n	100	69	70
sex (female)	69	46	45
age in years	25.95	25.32	29.99
English level (beginner 1 – 7 native-like)	4.77	4.06	7.00
Filler ranking ability (poor 0 – 16 accurate)	11.72	11.51	12.23

– altogether, 251 participants were recruited online; twelve needed to be excluded
– all participants completed a detailed questionnaire about their biography and learner history, part of which you see here
– according to their self-rated English proficiency levels, the German participants were more proficient than the Chinese participants; however, self-ratings might not be reliable
– therefore, a more reliable and objective proficiency measure was computed for each participant based on their filler ratings: the measure potentially ranged from zero to sixteen with zero indicating low proficiency and sixteen high proficiency; German and Chinese participants performed similarly on this measure but worse than English participants

Material

- preposition placement (fronting/stranding)
- word-by-word translational equivalence of prepositional verb (equivalent/not equivalent)

(5) I know the man ___ who(m) Jane ___ ___ .

a. I know the man on whom Jane relied.

b. I know the man who Jane relied on.

c. I know the man in whom Jane believes.

d. I know the man who Jane believes in.

(6) There's a bug which has caused major problems.

(7) Enjoyed I the time which was I given.

(part of material taken from Hoffmann, 2011)

– for a repeated-measures design, eight experimental and sixteen filler sentences were created
– the experimental sentences included *wh* RCs like (5) which systematically varied...
— preposition placement: the preposition was either fronted (like in (5a) and (5c)) or stranded (like in (5b) and (5d))
— English-German translational equivalence of the prepositional verb: the verb was either equivalent (like *rely on* in (5a) and (5b)) or not (like *believe in* in (5c) and (5d))
– moreover, there were eight grammatical and eight non-grammatical filler sentences, for example, (6) and (7)

Procedure and Statistical Modeling

procedure

- magnitude estimation task (Sorace, 2010; Cowart, 1997)
- internet-based experimentation using software and server of Ibex farm (Drummond, 2013)

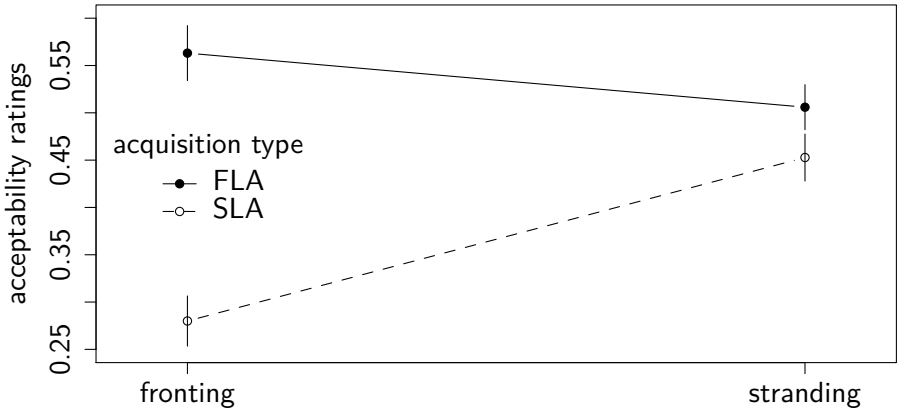
statistical modeling

- ratings were logarithmized and z-transformed
- two linear mixed effects models were fitted in a top-down procedure (Zuur, Ieno, Walker, Saveliev, & Smith, 2009)
- statistical modeling was done in R (R Core Team, 2013), the model was fitted with the lme4 package (Bates, Mächler, Bolker, & Walker, 2015)

– to elicit acceptability judgements, I adopted a method from psychometric studies: magnitude estimation; participants were asked to rate the acceptability of a sentence not on a Likert scale but in proportion to a reference sentence and express their estimations as multiples or fractions of the reference sentence value; this procedure produces an open-ended, participant-specific scale; for statistical analysis, ratings were logarithmized and z-transformed
– for experimentation, I used software and server of Ibex farm (Drummond, 2013) and distributed the link to the experiment on the internet
– two linear mixed effects models were fitted to the data, one to compare native to non-native participants and one to compare German to Chinese learners of English

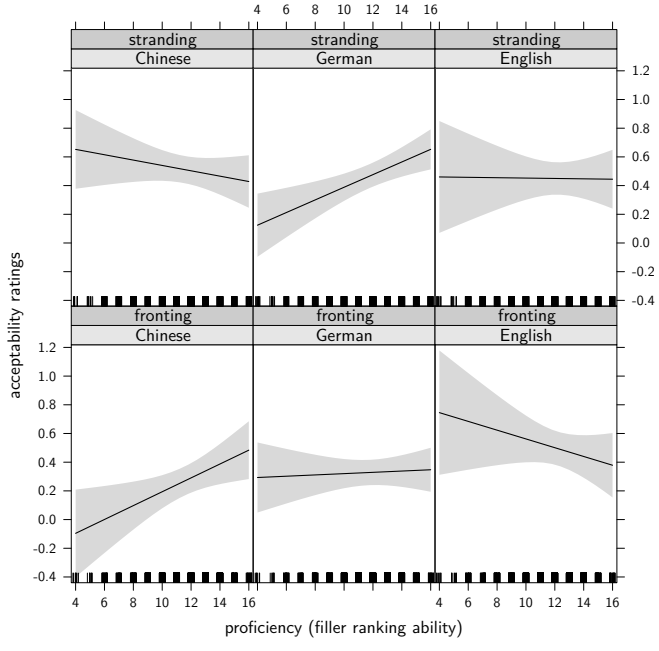
Results

Figure: Mean acceptability of preposition fronting and stranding in first and second language acquisition participants; vertical bars indicate standard errors



PREP. PLACE.: stranding × ACQUISITION TYPE: SLA $\beta = 0.226$, $p < 0.01$

– first, compare native to non-native learners; as is evident from the figure here...
– non-native learners (dashed line) rated stranding (right) more acceptable than fronting (left)
– in contrast, native learners (solid line) slightly favored fronting over stranding
– the statistical model indicated that this interaction between preposition placement and acquisition type was highly significant



PREP. PLACE.: stranding × L1: German $\beta = -1.344$, $p < 0.01$

PROFICIENCY × PREP. PLACE.: stranding × L1: German $\beta = 0.107$, $p < 0.01$

– second, compare German to Chinese learners of English

– as predicted, fronting was on average more acceptable to German than Chinese learners

– however, the statistical model indicated that the two-way interaction between preposition placement and first language was influenced by English proficiency; the emerging picture was more complex...

– the figure here plots preposition placement (rows) against first languages (columns), proficiency level (x-axis in each panel), and acceptability ratings (y-axis in each panel)

– as is evident from the figure, three first-language specific developmental patterns emerged

– let's focus on the second language learners

— in Chinese learners (left column), stranding (upper left panel) was on a high level of acceptability in low-proficiency learners and decreased with increasing proficiency; in contrast, the acceptability of fronting (lower left panel) was low in low-proficiency learners and increased with increasing proficiency

— in German learners (middle column), stranding (upper middle panel) was on a low level of acceptability in low-proficiency learners and increased with increasing proficiency; fronting (lower middle panel), however, was on an invariably high level of acceptability

— moreover, note that on the highest level of proficiency, acceptability ratings tended to converge across learner groups on a native-like point

— last, note that translational equivalence had no significant influence on the ratings

Discussion

1. acceptability is contingent on frequency in English input

Table: Distribution of preposition fronting and stranding across clause types in ICE-GB (based on Hoffmann, 2011, Table 4.4, p. 120, and Table 4.16, p. 148)

	***wh* RCs**	non-*wh* RCs	free RCs	pass	int	...	$\sum$
fronting	**439**	0	4	0	12	...	**455**
stranding	**69**	348	157	97	140	...	**811**
$\sum$	508	348	161	97	152	...	1266

- L2 learners have become attuned to marginal frequencies
- L1 learners have become attuned to joint frequencies

(Schmid, 2015; Ellis, Simpson-Vlach, & Maynard, 2008)

– I hypothesized, first, that acceptability of preposition fronting and stranding would be contingent on their distribution in language use
– for example, here is the distribution of fronting and stranding across clause types in the British part of ICE; note that while stranding is more frequent than fronting across all contexts (row totals in last column), fronting is more frequent than stranding in *wh* RCs (joint frequencies in second column)
– accordingly, I suggest that
— my SL learners have become attuned to the marginal distribution of fronting and stranding across all clause types and contexts – what Schmid (2015) refers to as cotext-free entrenchment – and, as a consequence, favored stranding over fronting
— in contrast, my FL learners have become attuned to joint probability distributions – Schmid's co(n)textual entrenchment – and, therefore, given the *wh* RCs in my experimental material, they favored fronting over stranding
– this ties in with earlier research on the sensitivity of processing to usage frequencies; for example, Ellis et al. (2008) have explored the influence of corpus measures like absolute frequency and collocational strength on the processing of lexical strings in native and non-native language users; notably, while non-native processing was best predicted by absolute string frequency, native processing was by collocational strength
– I suggest that, in a similar way, my SL learners have acquired fronting and stranding based on absolute counts across all contexts, whereas my FL learners have tailored their constructions to the particular contexts in which the have experienced them most frequently
– this was most visible in the ratings by my Chinese learners: low-proficiency learners favored stranding over fronting, reflecting marginal relative frequencies in their input; increasing in proficiency and exposure, they gradually adjust the use of their constructions to particular contexts and, thus, become more native-like

Discussion

2. fronting is more acceptable to German than to Chinese learners due to cross-linguistic similarity

(3) a. *Ich habe keinen bestimmten Typ,* ***auf den*** *ich stehe.*
I have no particular type on whom I stand

'There is no particular type (of man or woman) who I like.' (LCC)

(4) *wǒ xiūlǐ shuǐ guǎnzi de jùzi* (Li & Thompson, 1981, p. 581)
I repair water pipe NOM saw

'the saw with which I repair the water pipe'

- German learners acquire a fronting RC 'diaconstruction' (Höder, 2012, 2014)

(Diessel, 2004; Hilpert & Östman, 2014; Hartsuiker & Bernolet, 2017)

– second, I hypothesized that fronting would be more acceptable to German than to Chinese learners – this was borne out by the data, too
– I propose that this was due to due to cross-linguistic similarity between English and German fronting RCs
– prototypical fronting RCs in English and German share word order and grammatical categories; consider example (3a) again; ... ; English and German RCs share the order of preposition before *wh* relative pronoun; the RCs follow the modified noun and, prototypically, have the word order *object complement/adjunct – subject (often pronoun) – verb* in common
– compare this once more to prototypical Chinese RCs like (4) from earlier: there is neither a preposition nor a *wh* word, the RC precedes the noun, and has the word order SUBJECT – VERB – OBJECT
– thus, I propose that German but not Chinese learners of English draw on their first-language experience when acquiring fronting RCs in English because they perceive them as similar to their first-language constructions
– following Höder (2012, 2014), I suggest that German learners of English acquire a diaconstruction which links their German construction to the emerging English construction of fronting RCs and represents what is common to them
– this is in line with earlier usage-based research emphasizing the importance of word order similarity in the acquisition of RCs (e.g., Diessel, 2004) and relates to recent proposals in Construction Grammar and psycholinguistics that multilinguals acquire shared representations across their languages (e.g., Hilpert & Östman, 2014; Hartsuiker & Bernolet, 2017)

Thank you for your attention.

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	Dependent variable:
	acceptability ratings
(Intercept)	0.079 (0.119)
	t = 0.670
prep. place.: stranding	−0.044 (0.055)
	t = −0.790
acquisition type: SLA	−0.181 (0.074)
	t = −2.466**
English daily	0.043 (0.009)
	t = 4.789***
proficiency (filler ranking ability)	0.014 (0.007)
	t = 2.073**
prep. place.: stranding × acquisition type: SLA	0.226 (0.066)
	t = 3.419***
Observations	1,912
Note:	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

	Dependent variable:
	acceptability ratings
(Intercept)	−0.523 (0.234)
	t = −2.237**
proficiency	0.048 (0.020)
	t = 2.460**
prep. place.: stranding	1.016 (0.318)
	t = 3.201***
first language: German	0.564 (0.291)
	t = 1.943*
first language: English	1.157 (0.397)
	t = 2.917***
English daily	0.043 (0.009)
	t = 4.634***
proficiency × prep. place.: stranding	−0.067 (0.027)
	t = −2.451**
proficiency × first language: German	−0.044 (0.025)
	t = −1.772*
proficiency × first language: English	−0.079 (0.032)
	t = −2.429**
prep. place.: stranding × first language: German	−1.344 (0.403)
	t = −3.337***
prep. place.: stranding × first language: English	−1.418 (0.545)
	t = −2.603***
proficiency × prep. place.: stranding × first language: German	0.107 (0.034)
	t = 3.105***
proficiency × prep. place.: stranding × first language: English	0.096 (0.045)
	t = 2.130**
Observations	1,912
Note:	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Material I

(8) I know the man on whom Jane relied.

(9) I know the man who Jane relied on.

(10) I know the man in whom Jane believes.

(11) I know the man who Jane believes in.

(12) Jennifer never calls the guys with whom she sleeps.

(13) Jennifer never calls the guys who she sleeps with.

(14) Jennifer never calls the guys for whom she falls.

(15) Jennifer never calls the guys who she falls for.

Material II

(16) Sally fancies the boy about whom Steve talked.

(17) Sally fancies the boy who Steve talked about.

(18) Sally fancies the boy to whom Steve talked.

(19) Sally fancies the boy who Steve talked to.

(20) You wouldn't believe the things about which Bill laughs.

(21) You wouldn't believe the things which Bill laughs about.

(22) You wouldn't believe the things at which Bill laughs.

(23) You wouldn't believe the things which Bill laughs at.

(24) Brad did something for which he never apologised.

Material III

(25) Brad did something which he never apologised for.

(26) Brad did something to which he never confessed.

(27) Brad did something which he never confessed to.

(28) Sarah never achieved the fame of which she dreamt.

(29) Sarah never achieved the fame which she dreamt of.

(30) Sarah never achieved the fame about which she dreamt.

(31) Sarah never achieved the fame which she dreamt about.

(32) Do you know the lady with whom he is speaking?

(33) Do you know the lady who he is speaking with?

Material IV

(34) Do you know the lady to whom he is speaking?

(35) Do you know the lady who he is speaking to?

(36) I didn't like the painting with which John compared me.

(37) I didn't like the painting which John compared me with.

(38) I didn't like the painting to which John compared me.

(39) I didn't like the painting which John compared me to.

(40) I expect my mummy and daddy to be exceptional which they never are.

(41) She writes some wonderful other books that I like.

Material V

(42) There's a bug which has caused major problems.

(43) You need something that you're going to enjoy.

(44) He didn't have to describe the woman who was sitting there.

(45) There's a bone in my nose that's slightly bent.

(46) They all tell me all the things that the books tell me.

(47) I presume it's something again which we haven't done.

(48) They has a conventional cooker as well which they was using.

(49) I doesn't know anyone else who could does it.

Material VI

(50) I had to meets these girl who I hasn't seen for ten years.

(51) There was lots of activity goes on there.

(52) We visited a wood in the morning was an oak wood.

(53) That's a tape sent I them that done I've myself.

(54) Having we're not the cottage that had we before.

(55) Enjoyed I the time which was I given.